



Brunel Business School

MG5638 Dissertation

Student ID:

Academic Year: 2023-2024

MSc Business Intelligence and Digital Marketing

**Consumer Perceptions and Preferences for Personalised Marketing
in the Era of GDPR: Balancing Customization and Data Privacy
(Word Count - 11397)**

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Acknowledgement

I would like to express my deepest gratitude to all those who have contributed for the completion of this dissertation.

First and foremost, I extend my heartfelt appreciation to my supervisor, Kinana Jammoul, for her invaluable guidance, support, and encouragement throughout the entire research process. Her expertise, patience, and constructive feedback have been instrumental in shaping this dissertation and refining my research skills.

I am also thankful to the faculty and staff of Brunel University London, whose dedication to excellence in education has provided me with the necessary resources and environment to pursue my academic endeavours.

I am indebted to the participants of this study, whose willingness to share their insights and experiences has enriched my research and contributed to the advancement of knowledge in the field of business intelligence and digital marketing.

Finally, I would like to express my gratitude to my family for their unwavering love, encouragement, and understanding during this challenging journey. Their support has been a constant source of motivation and strength.

This dissertation would not have been possible without the collective support and encouragement of all those mentioned above. Thank you for being part of this journey and for your invaluable contributions.

Abstract

This study dives into the awareness and perceptions of individuals regarding the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) and its implications on data privacy and personalised marketing. Through a comprehensive survey, data was collected on various aspects including familiarity with GDPR, confidence in rights granted by GDPR, experiences of privacy invasion, opt-out behaviours due to privacy concerns, reading of privacy policies on websites, trust in companies handling personal data, and the impact of GDPR compliance statements on trust levels.

The survey sample covered a diverse demographic, including individuals of different ages, genders, education levels, employment statuses, and familiarity with technology. Findings revealed a mixed level of understanding and engagement with GDPR across these groups. Notably, respondents expressed varying degrees of confidence in the rights provided by GDPR, with some feeling more secure and in control of their data due to the regulation, while others reported instances of privacy invasion that led to opting out of services.

Moreover, the study highlighted the importance of clear and understandable GDPR compliance statements and the necessity of explicit consent mechanisms before personal data processing. It was observed that GDPR has positively impacted individuals' feelings of control over their data and has increased transparency in data handling practices. As part of recommendations, the need for explicit and transparent communication to build trust with users came out as a primary output of the study

The research also shed light on the sources of information individuals rely on for understanding their rights and protections under GDPR. Online forums, news articles, and social media were identified as key sources of information, influencing individuals' perceptions and behaviours towards data privacy. Additionally, the study explored the main benefits of GDPR, with enhanced data protection, increased privacy, and greater control over personal information emerging as significant outcomes since the implementation of the regulation.

Overall, this study provides valuable insights for both practical applications and further research in the realm of data privacy and GDPR compliance. The data collected offers a rich dataset for analysing the impact of GDPR on user perceptions and behaviours, guiding companies in tailoring their privacy policies and communication strategies to align with user expectations. Future research can delve deeper into specific factors influencing individuals' attitudes towards data privacy and the effectiveness of GDPR in enhancing user privacy rights and protections.

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Chapter 1: Introduction

1.1 Background, brief overview of GDPR and its impact on personalised marketing

In the world of modern commerce, the convergence of digital technology, data analytics, and consumer connectivity has reshaped the way businesses interact with their audiences. Gone are the days of one-size-fits all marketing approaches. Today, companies harness the power of personalised marketing to forge deeper connections and drive engagement. This paradigm shift has grown in an era where businesses leverage sophisticated algorithms and vast buckets of consumer data to tailor their marketing messages, product recommendations, and overall customer experiences to individual preferences and behaviours. Personalised marketing especially has the ability to deliver relevant content and offerings that resonate with consumers on a personal level and thus enhancing engagement, driving conversions, and fostering long-term loyalty (Abimbola, 2023).

But amid the proliferation of personalised marketing strategies, a significant counterpoint has emerged which is the escalating demand for data privacy by consumers. In the information age where personal information is almost as valuable as currency, individuals are growing vigilant about safeguarding their digital identities and exercising control over how their data is collected, used, and shared (Lambillotte, Bart and Poncin, 2022). Digital media has heightened awareness of data privacy risks, coupled with high-profile data breaches and privacy scandals and has fueled concerns about the potential misuse of personal information by businesses and other entities. This evolving expectation of consumer and regulatory scrutiny has prompted policymakers to enact measures aimed at enhancing data protection and privacy rights (Smirity Kaushik, 2018).

To address such concerns, the European Union (EU) came up with one such legislative milestone called General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), in 2018. The GDPR represents a landmark initiative that seeks to empower individuals with greater control (Lambillotte, Bart and Poncin, 2022) over their personal data and impose stricter obligations on organisations that collect and process this information.

The GDPR has greatly reshaped the landscape of data collection and usage within the EU and beyond. It has established robust standards for data protection and privacy, the regulation aims to restore consumer trust and confidence in the digital ecosystem. At the heart of the GDPR are several key principles that govern the handling of personal data by organisations:

Transparency: Businesses are required to provide clear and easily accessible information about their data collection and processing practices. This includes disclosing the types of data collected, the purposes for which it is used, and the duration for which it will be retained. Transparency acts as a pillar of trust and empowers consumers to make informed decisions about their data.

Consent: The GDPR mandates that individuals must give explicit, informed, and freely given consent for the collection and processing of their personal data. To reduce the ambiguous use of pre-ticked checkboxes and vague privacy policies; under the GDPR, consent must be specific, granular, and revocable at any time (Michiel Rhoen, 2016). This places greater emphasis on proactive communication and affirmative consent from consumers.

Control: Perhaps most significantly, the GDPR grants individuals a range of rights to exercise control over their personal data. This includes the right to access their data, request corrections or deletions, and object to its processing under certain circumstances. The introduction of the "right to be forgotten" empowers individuals to assert greater control over their digital identities and limit the retention of their personal data by organisations (European Union, 2022).

The impact of the GDPR on personalised marketing practices is profound and far-reaching. Prior to the regulation, businesses often relied on implicit consent mechanisms, such as cookie tracking and behavioural targeting, to collect and leverage consumer data for personalised marketing purposes (Chandra et al., 2022). However, the GDPR's stringent requirements for explicit consent and transparent data processing have forced companies to reevaluate their data collection practices and marketing strategies. The era of indiscriminate data harvesting and intrusive targeting is giving way to a more nuanced approach that prioritises consumer consent, privacy, and trust.

1.2 Research problem and objectives

The ongoing evolving landscape of personalised marketing and data privacy, businesses are faced with a critical challenge: how to effectively harness the power of personalization while respecting consumer privacy rights and building trust (Smirity Kaushik, 2018). This tension underscores the need for a deeper understanding of consumer perceptions, attitudes, and preferences towards personalised marketing practices and data privacy considerations.

To address this pressing research problem, this study aims to investigate the following key research questions:

1. What is the level of consumer awareness regarding the data collection practices employed for personalised marketing?

- This question seeks to assess the extent to which consumers are aware of the types of data collected, the purposes for which it is used, and the mechanisms for giving consent.

2. Does the trade-off between personalization and data privacy vary across different consumer segments (age, demographics, tech-savviness)?

- This question explores whether different consumer groups prioritise personalization differently or exhibit varying levels of concern about data privacy. By examining demographic and psychographic factors, our aim is to identify nuanced patterns of consumer behaviour and preferences.

3. How do consumers perceive the effectiveness of existing opt-in and opt-out mechanisms for data collection in the context of personalised marketing?

- This question delves into consumer attitudes towards the mechanisms for giving or withdrawing consent for data collection. By assessing the perceived effectiveness and transparency of these mechanisms, we seek to identify opportunities for improvement in privacy communication and consent processes.

4. What strategies can businesses adopt to personalise marketing in a GDPR-compliant manner that fosters trust and addresses consumer privacy concerns?

- This question explores approaches and best practices for achieving effective personalization while adhering to data privacy regulations and consumer expectations. By identifying strategies

that balance personalization and privacy, we aim to provide actionable insights for businesses seeking to navigate the complex landscape of modern marketing.

By addressing these research questions, we are looking to provide valuable insights into consumer attitudes towards personalised marketing in the era of data privacy regulations. By understanding the factors that shape consumer perceptions and preferences, we can suggest businesses to develop ethical and effective marketing strategies that enhance customer engagement, build trust, and drive sustainable growth in the digital age. Through collaboration and dialogue between businesses, policymakers, and consumers, it is possible to achieve a harmonious balance between personalised marketing and data privacy, thereby fostering a more equitable and transparent digital ecosystem for all stakeholders.

1.3 Dissertation structure overview

The structure of a dissertation is important in guiding the reader through the complex journey of research, laying a foundational blueprint for our study's trajectory. This dissertation is methodically divided into five distinct chapters, each serving a unique purpose in the overarching narrative of the research.

Chapter 1: Introduction

In this initial chapter, the background of the research area is presented, highlighting the context within which the study is conducted. It also includes the problem definition or research gap that the dissertation aims to address. Moreover, it introduces and outlines the specific aims and objectives of the research, setting the stage for the entire study.

Chapter 2: Literature Review

The second chapter, the literature review, talks about existing scholarly works and research relevant to the topic of study. This section critically evaluates and synthesises the literature to provide a comprehensive understanding of the subject matter, highlighting key theories, concepts, and findings that inform the research.

Chapter 3: Research Methods

This section focuses on the research methodology employed in the study. It details the research approach taken, the specific methods used to collect and analyse data, and any tools or instruments utilised in the research process. This chapter essentially explains how the data was gathered and processed to address the research questions.

Chapter 4: Results/Findings

In the results and findings chapter, the analysis and outcomes of the research are presented. This section showcases the data analysis process, the results obtained, and how these findings align with the research objectives. It is crucial for demonstrating the validity and reliability of the study's outcomes.

Chapter 5: Discussion/Conclusion/Recommendations

The final chapter of the dissertation summarises the entire research endeavour. It encapsulates the key findings, contributions made by the study, and any implications for theory, practice, or future research. Additionally, this chapter acknowledges the limitations of the study, proposes areas for further research, and offers practical recommendations based on the research outcomes.

This structured approach ensures a comprehensive and coherent presentation of the research process, findings, and implications, guiding readers through the study's progression and outcomes effectively.

Chapter 2: Literature review

2.1 History of GDPR

The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) stands as a major legal framework that has significantly impacted digital marketing practices worldwide. It was enforced in May 2018 and was designed to harmonise data privacy laws and reshape the way organisations approach data protection and privacy. Since it is a regulation and not a directive. The compliance is mandatory

and does not require each member state to ratify it into its own legislation.

The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) enables individuals to take control and unambiguously give consent for their personal data processing. These rights are designed to enhance privacy and give individuals more say in how their information is collected, processed, and used by organisations. While the GDPR exclusively safeguards the rights of UK citizens, its ramifications extend globally, impacting any entity targeting the UK market or offering services while holding personally identifiable information on UK residents. The GDPR provides consumers with a significant level of control, encompassing rights such as the ability to withdraw consent (Article 7) and be forgotten (Article 17) (UK Government, 2016). Simultaneously, stringent requirements are imposed on data controllers and processors, including the implementation of data protection by design and by default (Article 25) and the meticulous recording of all processing activities (Article 30). The GDPR mandates that organisations secure user consent for data collection and "implement appropriate technical and organisational measures" to safeguard the personal data of UK residents (Smirity Kaushik, 2018).

From a corporate perspective, failure to adhere to the GDPR could result in substantial penalties, including fines ranging from a minimum of 2% (or 10 million euros) to a maximum of 4% of global revenue (or 20 million euros or more, whichever is higher). These significant penalties provide a compelling reason for companies to review and revise their privacy policies and practices to align with GDPR requirements. Additionally, a burgeoning industry has emerged, offering tools and services focused on GDPR compliance to assist companies in navigating and meeting these regulatory standards (Smirity Kaushik, 2018).

In the world of personalised marketing, GDPR plays a crucial role in governing how businesses collect, store, process, and utilise personal data of individuals within the UK. Personal data includes information from which a person could be identified, either directly or indirectly (Tankard, 2016). This regulation has profound implications for businesses engaging in personalised marketing activities, necessitating a fundamental shift in their approach to data handling and consumer interactions.

Significance of GDPR in Personalised Marketing

The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) is significant in the UK as it sets out rules for how personal data should be handled, enhancing data privacy and protection. The GDPR applies to all organisations that process personal data of individuals in the European Economic Area (EEA), including the UK. It aims to harmonise data privacy laws, providing individuals with rights such as being informed about data collection, accessing their data, and having it deleted if necessary.

In the UK, the GDPR is retained as the UK GDPR, alongside an amended version of the Data Protection Act 2018. The key principles, rights, and obligations remain the same under the UK GDPR. Businesses in the UK must comply with both UK and EU data protection regulations if they operate within the EEA or offer goods/services to individuals in the EEA. Non-compliance with GDPR can lead to significant fines of up to €20 million or 4% of global revenue (org ,uk, 2023).

Overall, GDPR plays a crucial role in safeguarding personal data, ensuring transparency, fairness, and accountability in data processing practices within the UK and across the EEA.

1. Enhanced Data Protection

The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) in the UK, known as the UK GDPR, is crucial for data protection and privacy. It requires organisations to implement appropriate technical and organisational measures to uphold data protection principles. The UK Government has proposed key changes through the Data Protection and Digital Information Bill to provide organisations with more flexibility in using personal data while reducing compliance burdens (brown, 2023).

After Brexit, the UK-GDPR replaced the EU GDPR in the UK, ensuring data privacy compliance. It aligns closely with the EU GDPR, requiring explicit consent for processing personal data via cookies and granting individuals rights like data access and deletion (PSA Professional Solutions , n.d.). The UK-GDPR expands on the EU GDPR by addressing areas like national security, intelligence services, and immigration, setting exceptions for data protection in these domains.

Overall, the UK GDPR plays a vital role in safeguarding personal data, ensuring compliance with data protection laws, and enhancing privacy rights for individuals within the UK.

2. Consumer Trust and Transparency

Consumer trust and transparency play crucial roles in the context of GDPR in the UK. The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) and its UK counterpart emphasise the importance of fostering trust between consumers and organisations handling their personal data. Compliance with GDPR principles, including obtaining explicit and informed consent, transparent data processing practices, and clear communication about the purpose of data collection, is essential for building and maintaining consumer trust. The regulations require businesses to be transparent about how they use and protect consumer data, providing individuals with greater control over their personal information. Demonstrating a commitment to data protection and ensuring compliance not only safeguards consumers' privacy rights but also establishes a foundation of trust that is vital for successful and ethical business practices in the evolving landscape of digital data management (Burton, 2016). Through transparency and adherence to GDPR principles, organisations can strengthen their relationships with consumers and demonstrate a commitment to responsible data handling practices.

3. Impact on Marketing Strategies

The implementation of the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) has had a profound impact on marketing strategies, particularly in the United Kingdom. GDPR places stringent requirements on how businesses collect, process, and use personal data, necessitating a reevaluation of traditional marketing approaches. Marketers are now compelled to prioritise transparency, explicit consent, and data security. The era of indiscriminate data collection has given way to a more selective and user-centric approach, where individuals have greater control over their data. This shift has prompted marketers to adopt more targeted and personalised strategies based on opt-in consent, as opposed to relying on broad data acquisition practices (Fridh and Dahl, 2019). While the regulations present challenges, they also offer an opportunity for marketers to build trust with consumers by demonstrating a commitment to privacy and ethical data handling. In essence, GDPR has reshaped marketing strategies, fostering a more responsible and consumer-centric approach that aligns with evolving expectations for data protection and privacy.

4. Global Influence

The influence of the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) extends far beyond its initial implementation in the European Union. Its global impact has shaped the landscape of data protection and privacy regulations worldwide (Li, Yu and He, 2019). Many countries and regions have taken cues from GDPR's principles and standards, either by adopting similar frameworks or by enhancing their existing data protection laws. Organisations operating on a global scale are compelled to navigate a complex web of varying data protection requirements, aligning their practices with the highest standards to ensure compliance across jurisdictions. This harmonisation of data protection standards on a global scale signifies a growing recognition of the importance of safeguarding individuals' privacy rights and fostering responsible data handling practices. GDPR has set a benchmark, influencing discussions and policies on data protection beyond the EU, emphasising the need for a comprehensive and user-centric approach to managing personal information in the digital age.

5. Legal Compliance and Avoidance of Penalties

Ensuring legal compliance and avoiding penalties is a paramount concern for businesses in the context of data protection regulations, such as the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) in the UK. Organisations must meticulously adhere to the stipulations outlined in these regulations to mitigate the risk of financial penalties and legal consequences. GDPR mandates transparent and lawful processing of personal data, explicit user consent, and robust security measures. Failing to comply with these requirements can result in substantial fines, with penalties reaching up to €20 million or 4% of global turnover. To sidestep such penalties, businesses must invest in comprehensive data protection policies, conduct regular risk assessments, and implement stringent security measures. Demonstrating a commitment to legal compliance not only safeguards against financial repercussions but also builds trust with consumers, reinforcing the notion that their privacy is a top priority for the organisation. In essence, adherence to data protection regulations is not just a legal necessity but a strategic imperative for organisations seeking to operate ethically, avoid penalties, and cultivate a secure and trustworthy relationship with their customers.

In conclusion, the background and significance of GDPR in personalised marketing underscore its transformative impact on how businesses collect and utilise consumer data. By prioritising data protection, transparency, and consumer rights, GDPR has reshaped the personalised marketing landscape, emphasising ethical practices and accountability in an era where data privacy is paramount. Adapting to the requirements of GDPR is not merely a legal obligation but a strategic imperative for businesses looking to build trust with consumers, enhance brand reputation, and navigate the evolving landscape of personalised marketing responsibly.

2.2 Consumer perceptions of personalised marketing

Consumer perceptions of personalised marketing play a pivotal role in shaping their interactions with brands and influencing their purchasing decisions. Research by (Fridh, 2019) emphasises that personalised marketing has evolved from traditional mass marketing to extreme segmentation, targeting individual consumers based on their specific needs and preferences. This shift has sparked discussions on whether personalised marketing creates privacy concerns or benefits in the eyes of consumers. The study aims to explore how consumer perception of personalised marketing impacts the purchase decision-making process, highlighting the importance of understanding consumer attitudes towards customization.

Moreover, a study by Sipior, Ward, & Mendoza (2011) suggests that successful personalised marketing can positively influence the decision-making process by providing tailored offerings that match consumer needs and preferences. However, the debate continues on whether personalised marketing builds relationships or raises privacy concerns. While accurate personalization can guide consumers through decision-making, overly precise targeting may deter them from engaging with personalised offers (van Doorn & Hoekstra, 2013). This underscores the delicate balance businesses must strike to ensure personalised marketing resonates with consumers without overwhelming them.

Furthermore, research by Dahl & Fridh (2019) delves into the impact of personalised marketing on different stages of the consumer decision-making process. The study reveals that a positive perception of personalised marketing makes consumers more receptive to it, influencing various stages of decision-making. Consumers' past experiences, privacy concerns, and perceptions of genuineness and added value all contribute to how they perceive personalised marketing

initiatives. Understanding these factors is crucial for businesses seeking to tailor their strategies effectively to meet consumer expectations and preferences.

In essence, consumer perceptions of personalised marketing are multifaceted, influenced by factors such as trust, privacy concerns, and the relevance of customised offerings. By aligning marketing strategies with consumer preferences and addressing privacy considerations transparently, businesses can enhance consumer trust and engagement in an era where personalization plays a central role in shaping brand-consumer relationships.

2.3 The role of GDPR in shaping consumer preferences

The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) has emerged as a significant regulatory framework impacting consumer preferences and behaviours regarding data privacy. Implemented in Europe in May 2018, the GDPR has reshaped how consumers perceive and engage with organisations in terms of their personal data protection and usage. Studies have highlighted the profound influence of the GDPR on consumer awareness, trust, and expectations regarding data privacy rights and protections.

(Janssen et al., 2022) argue that the GDPR has implications for consumer surplus, suggesting that it may reduce innovation in consumer products, thus impacting consumer welfare. This perspective underscores the complex interplay between regulatory compliance and consumer outcomes, emphasising the need to balance data protection with innovation in consumer offerings. Additionally, the GDPR's focus on enhancing consumer privacy through improved data security and restrictions on data processing has led to changes in marketing strategies, particularly affecting personalised marketing channels like email and online display advertising. Furthermore, the GDPR has prompted organisations to adopt more consumer-centric approaches, emphasising transparency, consent, and data security in their interactions with consumers. This shift towards consumer empowerment and data protection has influenced consumer preferences, with individuals increasingly favouring companies that prioritise privacy and demonstrate a commitment to safeguarding personal information.

In conclusion, the GDPR has played a transformative role in shaping consumer preferences by elevating awareness about data privacy rights, fostering trust between consumers and organisations, and driving changes in marketing practices to align with regulatory requirements.

By prioritising transparency, consent, and data security, organisations can enhance consumer trust and loyalty, ultimately influencing consumer choices and interactions in a data-driven environment governed by stringent privacy regulations.

2.4 Studies on the effectiveness of GDPR privacy labels

The effectiveness of GDPR privacy labels in influencing consumer perceptions and behaviours has been a subject of scholarly inquiry, shedding light on the impact of these regulatory measures on data privacy and trust. Research by (Janssen et al., 2022) emphasises the importance of GDPR privacy labels in enhancing consumer perceptions of risk, control, privacy, and trustworthiness. The study suggests that GDPR labels positively influence consumer attitudes towards data protection and trust in organisations' data handling practices.

Moreover, Wang et al. (2023) and Aridor et al. (2022) have conducted empirical studies to examine the effectiveness of GDPR privacy labels in shaping consumer behaviour and decision-making processes. Aridor et al. highlight the role of GDPR privacy labels in improving consumer willingness to engage with personalised services and share personal information based on transparent data processing practices. This research underscores the significance of clear communication through privacy labels in building consumer trust and confidence in data-driven interactions.

Additionally, a study by (Fridh, 2019) explores the impact of GDPR privacy labels on consumer perceptions of privacy post-GDPR implementation. The findings suggest that traditional privacy policies may not effectively inform consumers or alleviate privacy concerns, highlighting the need for more transparent and accessible information through GDPR privacy labels. This research underscores the potential of GDPR labels to enhance consumer understanding of data processing practices and foster a sense of control over personal information sharing.

In conclusion, studies examining the effectiveness of GDPR privacy labels have demonstrated their positive influence on consumer perceptions of risk, control, and trustworthiness regarding data privacy. By providing clear and concise information through these labels, organisations can

enhance consumer trust, mitigate privacy concerns, and promote transparency in data processing practices, ultimately contributing to a more informed and empowered consumer base.

2.5 The impact of GDPR on marketing strategies and customer relationships

The rise of personalised marketing, fueled by big data and sophisticated algorithms, has revolutionised how businesses connect with consumers (Kumar et al., 2017). However, growing consumer concerns about data privacy have led to regulations like the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) in the European Union (EU). Implemented in 2018, GDPR empowers individuals with greater control over their personal data and mandates transparency from businesses collecting and using that data (General Data Protection Regulation (EU) 2016/679). This has created a significant challenge for businesses as to how they can maintain effective personalization strategies that enhance customer relationships, while adhering to GDPR principles and fostering consumer trust.

2.6 GDPR's impact on data collection and consent

One of the most significant impacts of GDPR is on data collection practices. Previously, businesses might have relied on implicit consent, inferred from user behaviour on websites or apps, to gather information for personalization. However, GDPR demands explicit opt-in consent, requiring users to actively agree to data collection (Ibarrola & Vilà, 2019). This makes acquiring the data necessary for highly targeted marketing campaigns more challenging.

Furthermore, GDPR grants consumers the "right to be forgotten," allowing them to request the erasure of their personal data (Article 17, General Data Protection Regulation (EU) 2016/679). This can limit the pool of data available for personalization and force businesses to re-evaluate their data retention policies.

2.7 Shifting towards transparency and building trust

With these restrictions, businesses must adapt their marketing strategies to navigate the landscape of data privacy. A key element is fostering transparency with customers. GDPR mandates clear and accessible information about data collection practices, including the type of data collected, its purpose, and how long it will be retained (Article 13, General Data Protection Regulation

(EU) 2016/679). Providing detailed privacy policies and user-friendly interfaces for accessing and managing data allows consumers to make informed choices about their information (Acquisti et al., 2016).

Building trust with consumers is paramount. Studies show that consumers are more likely to embrace personalization when they trust how their data is collected, used, and protected (Chen & Zhan, 2019). Businesses can build trust by demonstrating a commitment to data security and adhering to GDPR regulations.

2.8 Personalised Marketing in a GDPR-Compliant World

Still within the confinements of GDPR there is a huge opportunity for effective personalization. It also opens some new areas to explore and innovate. Below are some strategies which can be followed:

- **Focus on Contextual Personalization:** Personalization can still occur based on contextual factors like browsing history on a specific website or location data for in-store promotions. This approach avoids collecting vast amounts of personal information.
- **Leverage zero-party data:** Businesses can encourage customers to voluntarily share preferences and interests through surveys, contests, or loyalty programs. This "zero-party data" provides valuable insights for personalization without relying on third-party sources (Van der Lans et al., 2019).
- **Offer value in exchange for data:** Providing clear benefits and incentives for providing data can encourage opt-in consent. This could involve personalised discounts, exclusive content, or a more tailored user experience (Nguyen et al., 2019).

The GDPR era demands a shift from data-centric marketing to a customer-centric approach. By prioritising transparency, building trust, and utilising alternative personalization strategies, businesses can navigate these regulations and foster positive customer relationships in the digital age.

Chapter 3: Methodology

Designing the research for a dissertation involves several critical decisions about the approach, methodologies, data collection, and analysis strategies. This comprehensive design is important to ensure that the research objectives are met effectively and that the study contributes valuable insights to the existing body of knowledge.

3.1 Conceptual framework

At first we came up with a conceptual framework (Varpio and Paradis, 2020) for our dissertation. Since our study is going to be based on based on our survey method and results involves identifying key concepts, variables, and their relationships relevant to our research questions

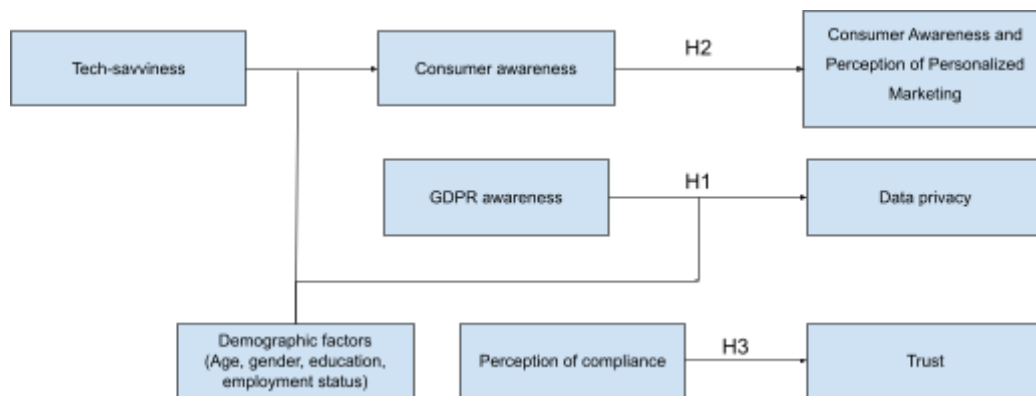


Fig 1: Proposed conceptual framework with key concepts and variables

1. Key Concepts:

- Data Privacy: The protection and control of personal data collected by businesses, including adherence to regulations such as the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) (Goddard, 2017).
- Consumer Awareness: Understanding and knowledge among consumers about data collection practices, privacy regulations, and the implications of personalised marketing (Addis and Kutar, 2018).

- Trust: The confidence and reliance consumers place in businesses to responsibly handle their personal data and deliver personalised experiences (Bleier and Eisenbeiss, 2015).

2. Variables:

- Independent Variables:
 - Demographic Factors (age, gender, education, employment status)
 - Tech-savviness Level
 - Awareness of GDPR
- Dependent Variables:
 - Perception of Personalised Marketing
 - Concerns about Data Privacy
 - Trust in Businesses

3. Relationships:

- Demographic Factors and Data Privacy Concerns:
 - H1: Demographic groups, such as younger consumers or those with higher education levels, may exhibit differing levels of concern about data privacy in personalised marketing contexts (Andrus et al., 2021).
- Consumer Awareness and Perception of Personalised Marketing:
 - H2: Higher awareness of data collection practices and GDPR correlates positively with favourable perceptions of personalised marketing (Strycharz, van Noort and Helberger, 2019).
- Trust and GDPR Compliance in Personalised Marketing:
 - H3: Trust in businesses is positively associated with perceptions of GDPR compliance in personalised marketing efforts, indicating that transparent and ethical data practices enhance consumer trust (Bleier and Eisenbeiss, 2015).

3.2 Research approach and method

The chosen research approach for this dissertation is quantitative (Park and Park, 2016), underpinned by the positivist paradigm (Park, Konge and Artino, 2020) that assumes a stable and measurable reality. This approach is justified by the study's aim to quantify relationships between variables related to individuals' perceptions and experiences of the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) in the context of personalised marketing. A quantitative approach enables the application of statistical analysis (Sheard, 2018) to test hypotheses derived from the research questions, providing a clear, numerical representation of trends, attitudes, and behaviours within the population of interest.

Research is of significant importance for both academics and businesses. Research is a structured and rigorous approach to advancing knowledge (Collis and Hussey, 2014). Furthermore, the methodology specifies how the research will be conducted and ensures consistency. The Melnikovas (2018) perspective contains a set of philosophical presumptions and beliefs that influence how the research questions are understood and how the research methodologies are chosen (Melnikovas, 2018).

A popular research methodology approach among academics is the one proposed by Saunders et al. (2019), known as the 'research onion' (Saunders, 2016). Overall, the research onion specifies the following layers to develop the methodology. Figure 2 demonstrates the chosen methodology for how this research was conducted.

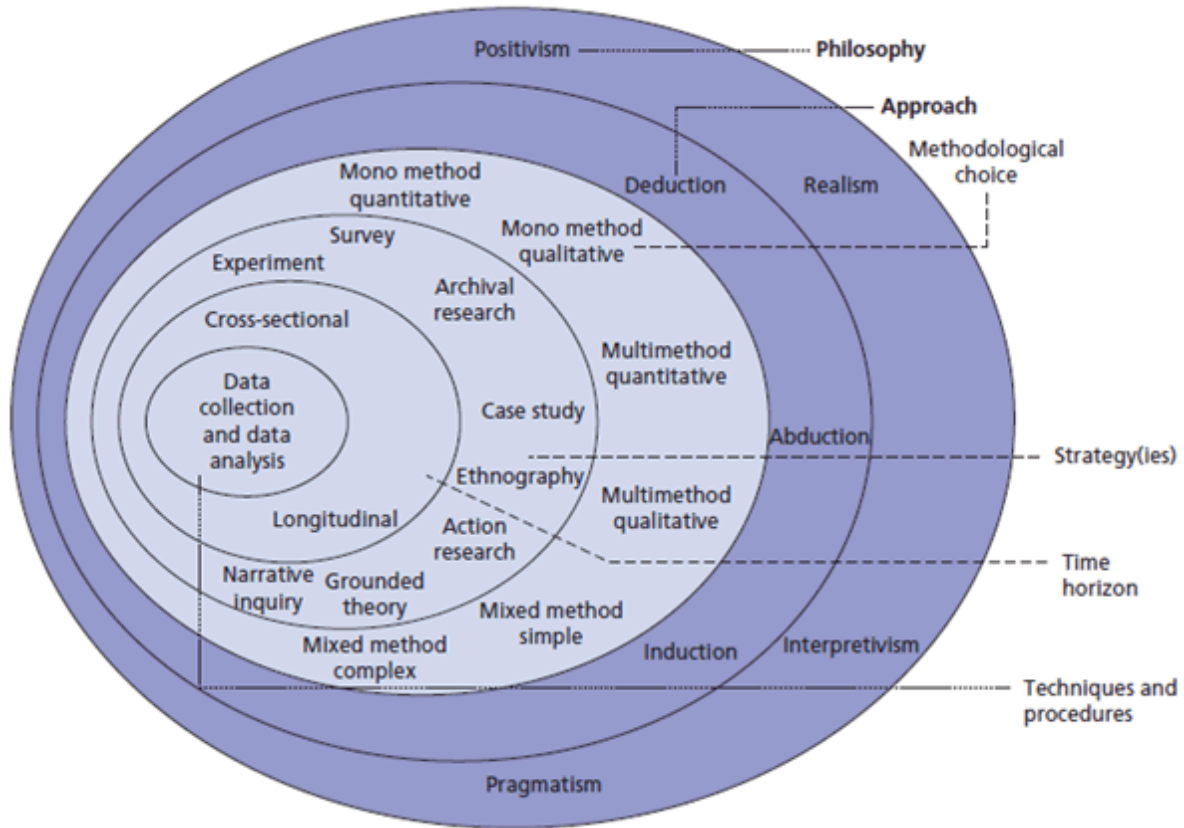


Fig 2: The research onion displaying the essence of research philosophy

3.2.1 Duration and time frame

Data collection occurred over a four-week period, leveraging online platforms to distribute the survey. This method was chosen for its efficiency, cost-effectiveness, and ability to reach a wide audience quickly (Couper, 2005). Prior to distribution, the survey underwent a pilot test with a small group of respondents to ensure clarity of the questions and the overall functionality of the survey instrument. Feedback from this pilot was used to make minor adjustments before the full launch.

The survey was distributed through social media platforms, forums related to personalised marketing and privacy, and email newsletters, targeting individuals likely to have experiences or opinions on the subject matter. Participants were informed of the study's purpose, assured of their anonymity, and given instructions on how to complete the questionnaire.

3.3 Research design

To align our research for this study we followed a multifaceted approach for research design:

1. **Alignment with Objectives:** The quantitative approach and structured survey method align perfectly with the study's objectives to measure and analyse the relationships between variables related to GDPR and personalised marketing. This design allows for the precise quantification needed to test the research hypotheses.
2. **Comprehensiveness:** The survey covers a broad range of questions that together provide a comprehensive understanding of the research problem. This thoroughness ensures that the study captures the multifaceted nature of individuals' experiences and attitudes toward GDPR and personal data privacy.
3. **Statistical Analysis:** The quantitative data collected through the Likert scale (Nemoto and Beglar, 2014) questions can be easily used for statistical analysis (McFadden et al., 2005), including correlation and regression analyses, to uncover patterns, trends, and relationships in the data. This ability to apply rigorous statistical techniques is crucial for validating the research hypotheses and drawing meaningful conclusions.
4. **Generalizability:** The use of a structured survey method allows for the collection of data from a broad sample of respondents, enhancing the generalizability of the findings. Although the sample size and selection method may limit the extent of this generalizability, the study provides a valuable snapshot of current attitudes and experiences related to GDPR in personalised marketing.
5. **Ethical Considerations:** The research design incorporates ethical considerations by ensuring anonymity and confidentiality for all participants. The voluntary nature of participation and the provision of clear information about the study's purpose and procedures uphold ethical standards and contribute to the reliability and integrity of the research process.

In summary, the research design for this dissertation is carefully crafted to align with the study's objectives, ensuring that the methodologies, data collection, and analysis strategies are all conducive to exploring the research questions in depth. The quantitative approach, combined

with the use of a structured Likert scale questionnaire and subsequent statistical analysis, provides a robust framework for understanding the nuances of public perceptions and experiences regarding GDPR in the realm of personalised marketing.

3.4 Sampling strategy and data collection methods

The survey comprised 20 questions, each designed to elicit responses on various dimensions of the participants' awareness, understanding, and experiences related to GDPR and personalised marketing. Questions ranged from demographic information (age, gender, education level, employment status) to more specific inquiries about the participants' familiarity with GDPR, their perceptions of its relevance to personal data privacy, and any encounters with personalised marketing that felt intrusive or violated their privacy. This breadth of questions was intended to capture a comprehensive view of the respondents' experiences and attitudes, providing a rich dataset for analysis.

The approach to sampling and data collection is carefully designed to ensure the inclusion of diverse perspectives while maintaining ethical standards and participant confidentiality.

Given the manageable anticipated response count, the study opts not to sample the results, meaning that all received responses will be included in the analysis. This decision allows for a more inclusive representation of participant viewpoints, reducing the risk of bias and enhancing the generalizability of findings. By including all received responses, the study aims to capture a wide range of perspectives and experiences, enriching the depth and breadth of the data collected.

The recruitment of participants was facilitated through online platforms, particularly WhatsApp groups, leveraging their widespread use and accessibility. WhatsApp groups offer a convenient and efficient means of reaching a diverse audience, allowing for broad recruitment across various demographic backgrounds. Participants were invited to participate in the study via WhatsApp groups, with recruitment messages containing a brief explanation of the study's purpose and instructions for participation.

To ensure a diverse and representative sample, efforts will be made to recruit participants from different demographic backgrounds, including varying age groups, genders, educational levels, occupations, and geographic locations. This diversity in participant demographics is essential for capturing a comprehensive understanding of consumer perceptions and preferences, accounting for potential variations across different segments of the population.

Participant anonymity and confidentiality are paramount considerations throughout the data collection process. To maintain participant privacy, demographic backgrounds will be anonymised, and identifiers will be removed from the dataset before analysis. This anonymization process ensures that individual participants cannot be identified based on their responses, safeguarding their confidentiality and privacy rights.

3.5 Questionnaire development for studying consumer awareness

The development of the questionnaire for this research is crucial in capturing consumer perceptions and preferences regarding personalised marketing and data privacy. This instrument aims to assess participant attitudes, awareness levels, and preferences through mostly closed-ended questions, enabling the collection of qualitative data. The questionnaire is meticulously designed for clarity and ease of response by organising questions into distinct thematic areas. Demographic information, encompassing factors like age, gender, education, and occupation, is collected at the questionnaire's conclusion to explore potential variations in awareness and preferences across different participant segments.

To ensure the questionnaire's effectiveness, we have divided it to measure multiple sections that correspond to different areas of survey

1. Demographics and GDPR Awareness (5 Questions):

- Familiar with "GDPR"
- Age, Gender, Education, Employment, Familiarity with technology

These questions establish a baseline understanding of the sample population and their general awareness of GDPR. This helps assess if responses are influenced by demographic factors or technological savviness.

2. Understanding and Impact of GDPR (10 Questions):

- GDPR in the context of personalised marketing
- GDPR relevant to your personal data privacy
- How confident are you in your understanding of the specific rights granted to you by GDPR
- GDPR has positively impacted the protection of personal information
- How you stay informed about your rights and protections under GDPR
- Interested in receiving more information about GDPR
- Do you feel more secure engaging with websites that explicitly mention GDPR compliance
- Do you believe that GDPR has had a positive impact on protecting consumer privacy in the era of personalised marketing

These questions delve deeper into consumers' understanding of GDPR's purpose and its effect on data privacy. They gauge their confidence in their GDPR knowledge, preferred information sources, and overall perception of its effectiveness in protecting consumer privacy in the context of personalised marketing.

3. Personal Experiences and Trust (7 Questions):

- Have you ever encountered a personalised marketing message that made you feel uncomfortable or invaded your privacy
- Frequently of privacy notices or consent requests related to GDPR when using online services
- Have you opted-out due to privacy concerns related to GDPR
- Do you read privacy policies on websites considering GDPR
- Trust companies to handle your personal data responsibly
- Comfortable with websites using your personal data for personalised marketing

These questions explore concrete user experiences with personalised marketing and privacy notices under GDPR. They assess consumer comfort levels with data collection practices and their trust in companies to handle personal data responsibly.

4. Perceived Benefits and Control (4 Questions):

- Main benefits of GDPR in protecting your personal data
- Does GDPR contribute to your feeling of control over your personal information

- Any positive outcomes related to data protection since the implementation of GDPR

These questions focus on the perceived benefits of GDPR for consumers. They explore if individuals feel a greater sense of control over their personal information due to GDPR regulations.

5. Transparency and Consent (3 Questions):

- Is GDPR effective in preventing unauthorised use of your personal information
- Has GDPR has increased transparency in how companies handle your data
- Should companies obtain your explicit consent before using your personal data for personalised marketing purposes
- Is it important for you that a website explicitly communicates its commitment to GDPR compliance

These questions investigate consumer perceptions of GDPR's effectiveness in preventing unauthorised data use and increasing transparency around data handling practices. They also assess their preference for explicit consent before personalised marketing and the importance of websites clearly communicating their GDPR compliance.

To visually represent the sample's demographic composition and contextualise the study's findings, three to four charts will be incorporated into the final report. These charts will provide valuable insights into the diversity of the participant pool.

3.6 Survey questions structure and wording

It is important to keep the question clear and concise. We should avoid leading questions or technical jargon that might confuse participants or influence their responses. We have also devised a pilot testing process that helps in identifying any such problems with the survey question structure or wording. Keeping the questions easy to understand, there is a higher chance to keep the survey free from bias and we ensure the data collected accurately reflects their true perceptions and preferences.

For instance, instead of asking open-ended and assertive questions, a more neutral phrasing would be a non-intrusive way to gather data. Pilot testing allows you to identify and refine such phrasing issues to ensure optimal clarity.

While comprehensiveness is important, a lengthy questionnaire can lead to participant fatigue and potentially lower response rates. Following are some strategies to keep participants engaged throughout:

- **Logical flow:** Organise the questionnaire logically with clear transitions between sections. This helps participants navigate the survey more easily.
- **Variety of question types:** Balance closed-ended and open-ended questions to avoid monotony. Closed-ended questions provide ease of response and data analysis, while open-ended questions allow for deeper insights into participant perspectives.
- **Clear instructions:** Provide clear and concise instructions at the beginning of each section. This ensures participants understand what is expected of them in each section.
- **Estimated time for completion:** Inform participants of the approximate time it should take to complete the questionnaire. This sets expectations and helps them manage their time effectively.

By incorporating these refinements, you can create a well-designed questionnaire that effectively measures consumer awareness of data collection practices and personalised marketing.

Chapter 4: Findings

This analysis delves into the complexities of consumer awareness and perceptions surrounding the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), data privacy, and personalised marketing practices. The data is based on a survey administered to a sample population, with a focus on understanding their familiarity with GDPR (Ashford, 2018), its connection to data privacy, and their personal experiences with personalised marketing.

4.1 Demographic considerations and potential variations

It's important to acknowledge the potential limitations of the sample demographics. The majority of respondents fell within the 25-34 age range (60.3%) and held Master's degrees (53.4%) (Q1, Q3).

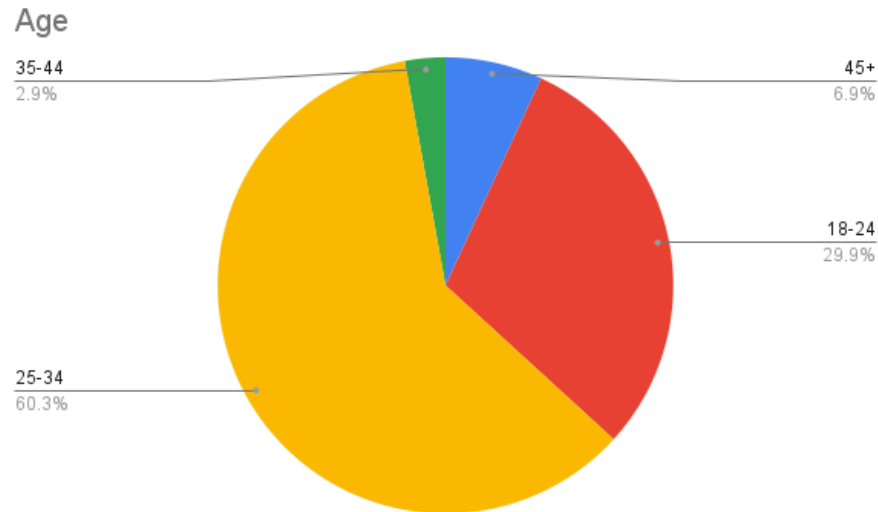


Fig 3: Age distribution of respondents

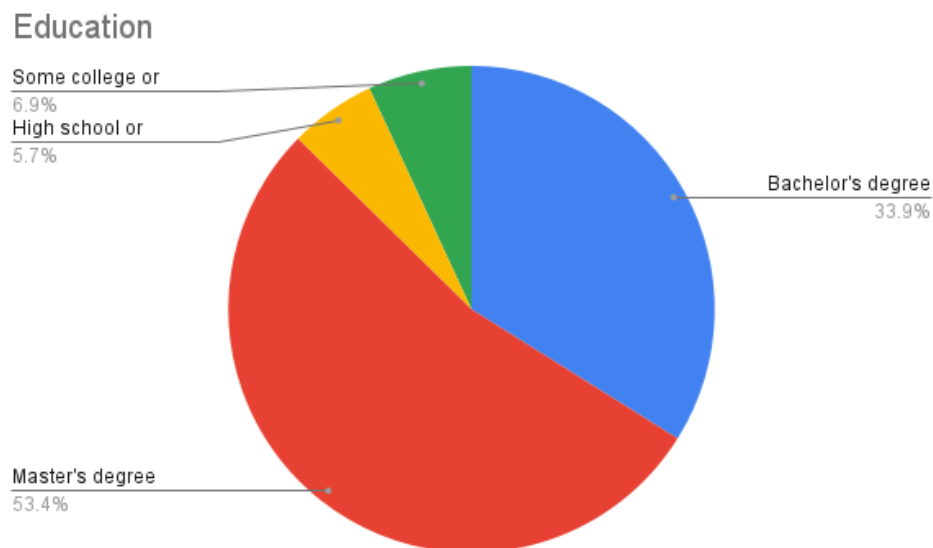


Fig 4: Level of education of respondents

In terms of gender, the sample is predominantly female (55.7%). This suggests a potentially tech-savvy and well-educated sample, which might influence overall awareness levels compared

to the general population. Future research efforts could benefit from including a more diverse sample to explore potential variations in awareness and perceptions across different demographics.

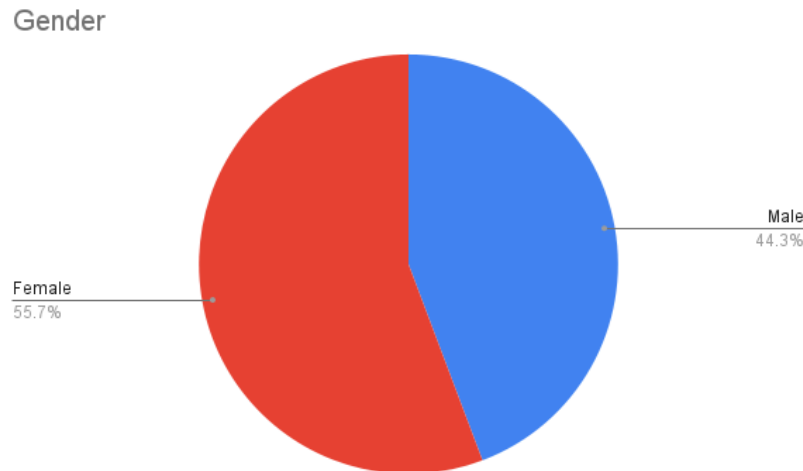


Fig 5: Gender distribution of respondents

4.2 Technology familiarity

Regarding familiarity with technology, the majority of respondents describe themselves as having an intermediate level of familiarity (63.2%), followed by advanced (25.9%) and novice (10.9%). When asked about their familiarity with GDPR, the responses indicate varying levels of awareness, with 31.0% somewhat familiar, 28.7% neutral, and 27.6% not very familiar. Notably, a small proportion (12.6%) report being very familiar with GDPR. This suggests that while some individuals have a basic understanding of GDPR, many respondents may require further education on this regulatory framework (Q5).

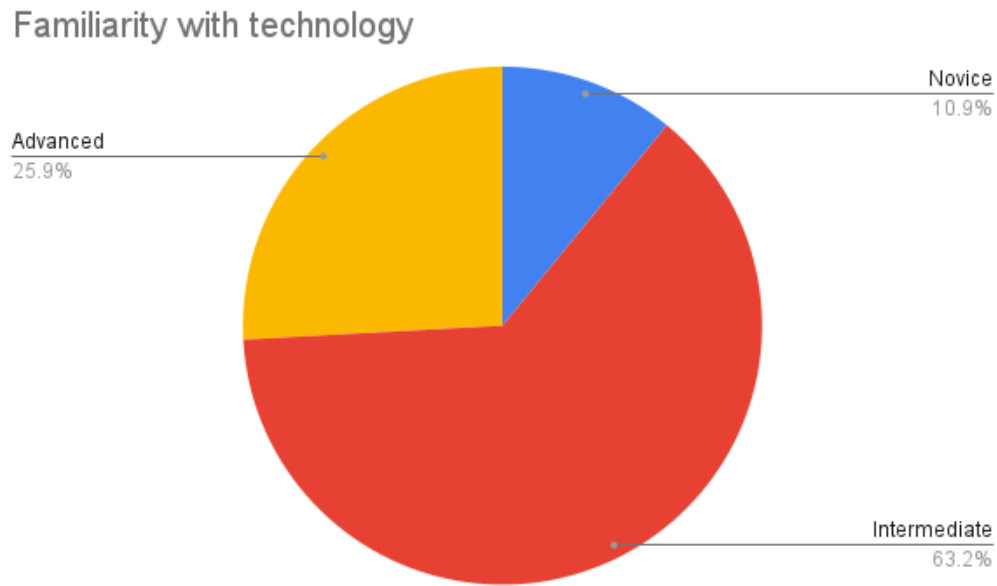


Fig 6: Familiarity with technology of respondents

4.3 Overall awareness of GDPR and personalised marketing strategies

While 41.2% of respondents reported some level of familiarity with the term "GDPR" (12.6% very familiar + 31.0% somewhat familiar), a significant portion (28.7% neutral + 27.6% not very familiar) lacked awareness (Q6). This initial finding highlights a potential knowledge gap regarding GDPR and its role in protecting user data privacy.

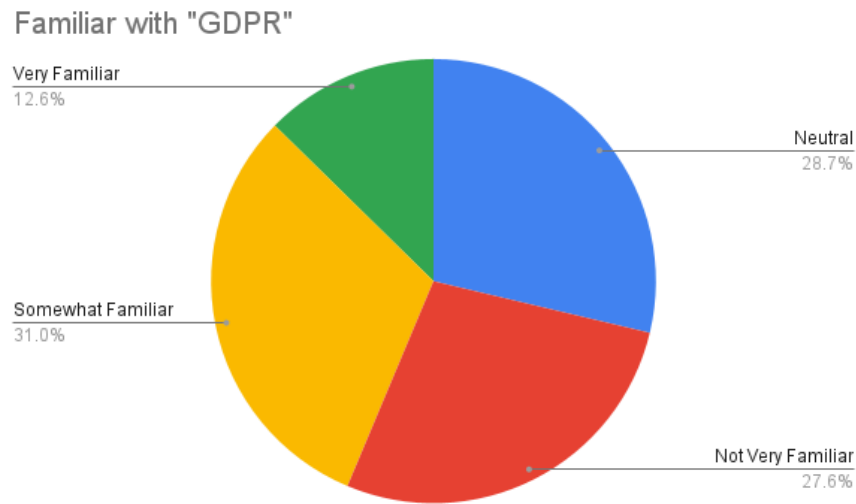


Fig 7: Familiarity with the term GDPR

However, a more nuanced understanding emerges when considering the context of personalised marketing (Question 7). A substantial 72.4% of participants indicated encountering or reading about GDPR in relation to personalised marketing. This suggests a growing association between GDPR and data privacy concerns specifically within the online advertising landscape.



Fig 8: Distribution of respondents aware of GDPR in context of personalised marketing

4.4 Perceptions of GDPR's relevance to data privacy

The survey explored consumer perceptions of GDPR's relevance to data privacy. A strong majority (73.6% - highly relevant + somewhat relevant) believed GDPR plays a role in protecting their personal data privacy when engaging with personalised marketing (Q8). This indicates a general understanding that GDPR regulations are relevant to online privacy concerns.

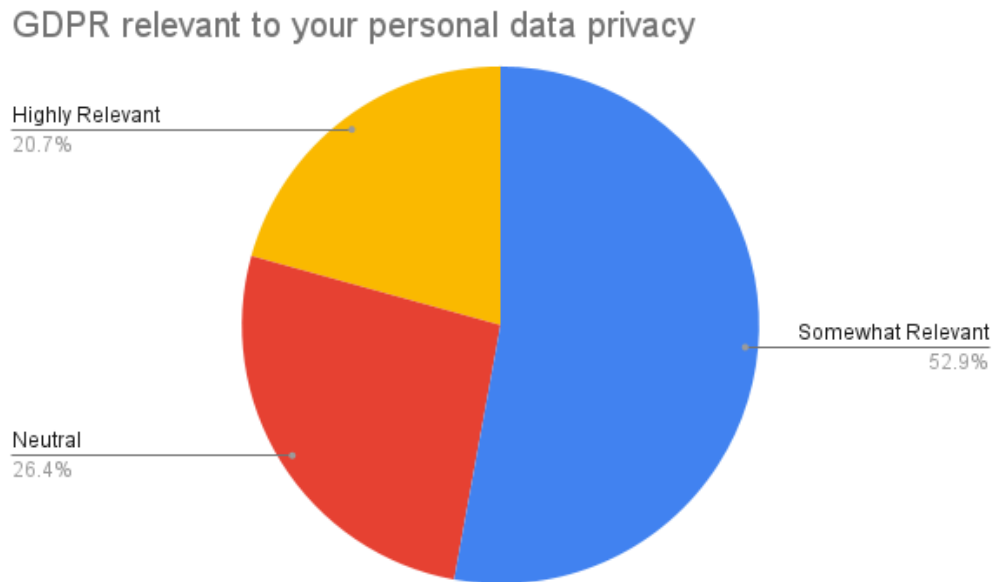


Fig 9: Distribution of respondents that consider GDPR relevant to personal data privacy

The analysis of perceptions of data protection and privacy delves into individuals' attitudes and beliefs regarding the importance of safeguarding personal information in the digital age. Over half of respondents (52.9%) consider GDPR to be somewhat relevant to their personal data privacy when engaging with personalised marketing, highlighting the perceived importance of regulatory compliance in safeguarding consumer information.

4.5 Confidence levels in understanding GDPR rights

However, a potential knowledge gap emerges regarding detailed knowledge of specific rights under GDPR. While only 18.4% reported high confidence in their understanding of these rights

(Q9), a larger portion (55.7%) had moderate confidence. This suggests that while a general awareness of GDPR exists, there's a need for initiatives that educate consumers about the specific rights and protections it offers.

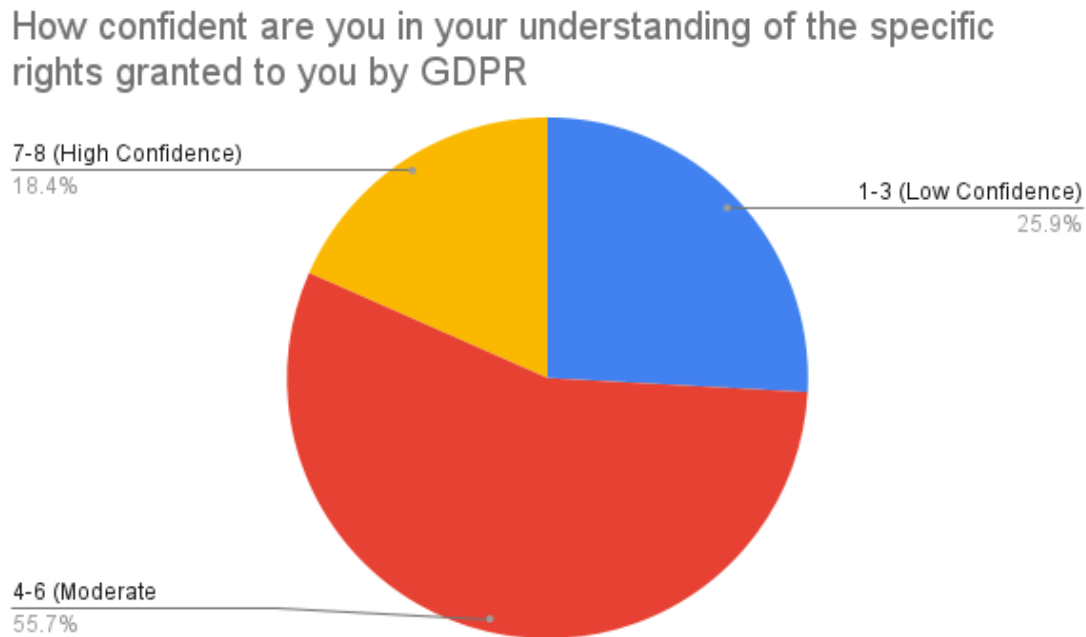


Fig 10: Distribution of respondents with respect to confidence in understanding specific rights granted by GDPR

4.6 Privacy concerns and discomfort with personalised marketing

The survey also explored consumer experiences with personalised marketing practices. Nearly half (60.3%) of participants reported encountering personalised marketing messages that made them feel uncomfortable or violated their privacy (Q10). This significant finding highlights a potential disconnect between the way businesses utilise consumer data for personalised marketing and user expectations around privacy. This discomfort suggests a need for businesses to re-evaluate their data collection practices and ensure alignment with user privacy concerns.

Have you ever encountered a personalised marketing message that made you feel uncomfortable or invaded your privacy

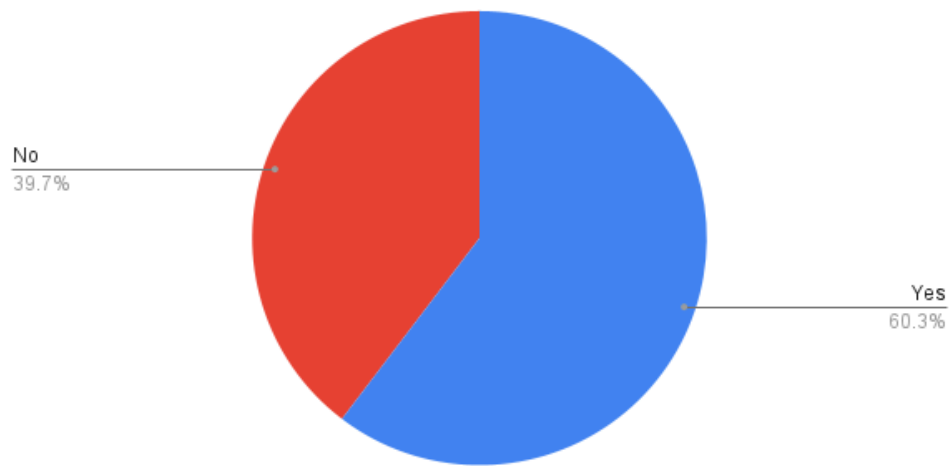


Fig 11: Distribution of respondents that encountered a marketing message that made them uncomfortable or invaded their privacy

4.7 Impact of GDPR's effectiveness on personal information protection

Regarding GDPR's impact on personal information protection online, the majority of respondents (56.9%) agree or strongly agree that GDPR has had a positive impact, suggesting a general perception of GDPR as a valuable tool for enhancing data protection. However, a significant proportion (36.8%) remain neutral on this issue, indicating a degree of uncertainty or ambivalence about GDPR's effectiveness in safeguarding personal information.

GDPR has positively impacted the protection of personal information

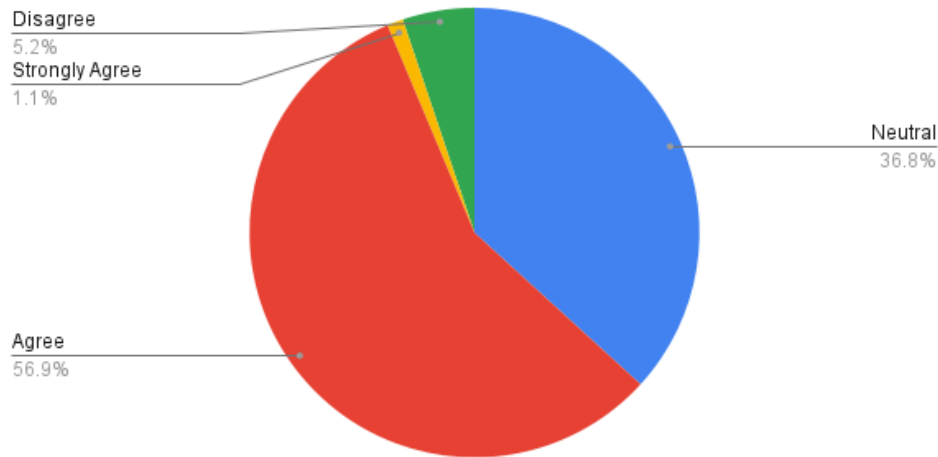


Fig 12: Distribution of respondents that believe GDPR has positively impacted and protected personal information

4.8 Unpacking the "Somewhat Familiar" category

While the survey categorised familiarity with GDPR as "very familiar," "somewhat familiar," "neutral," "not very familiar," and "not familiar at all" (Q6), a deeper understanding of the "somewhat familiar" category is needed. We need to understand the specific aspects of GDPR for these participants and if they understand the basic concept of data protection but lack knowledge of specific regulations or user rights. Further research using open-ended questions could provide more granular insights into the nuances of this category.

4.9 Exploring the discomfort with personalised marketing

The finding that nearly half of respondents experienced discomfort with personalised marketing warrants further exploration (Q10). What specific aspects of these marketing messages triggered feelings of discomfort? Was it the perceived intrusiveness, the lack of transparency about data collection practices, or a combination of factors? In-depth qualitative research could shed light on the specific reasons behind these negative experiences.

Overall, the analysis of perceptions of data protection and privacy highlights the complex interplay between regulatory frameworks, consumer attitudes, and business practices in shaping individuals' experiences in the digital marketplace. By addressing consumer concerns, promoting transparency, and prioritising data privacy in marketing.

Correlation Analysis: Unveiling Relationships

Correlation analysis (Senthilnathan, 2019) is a quantitative method employed to explore the strength and direction of the linear relationship between two variables. In the context of our survey data, it can be a powerful tool to investigate potential connections between various factors.

Mapping Survey Responses to Research Questions

- Research Question 1 (Consumer Awareness): Here, responses to questions on GDPR familiarity (Q6) and encounters with GDPR (Q7) can be correlated. By calculating the Pearson correlation coefficient, for example, we can determine if a higher reported familiarity with GDPR (a quantitative measure) is associated with an increased likelihood of recognizing GDPR in marketing contexts.
- Research Question 2 (Trade-off Analysis): To examine the trade-off between personalization and data privacy across demographics, responses from various demographic questions (Q1, Q2) and questions on comfort with data privacy in personalised marketing (Q10) can be correlated. The aim is to identify significant correlations that indicate demographic trends in privacy perceptions and preferences.
- Research Question 3 (Effectiveness of Opt-in/Opt-out Mechanisms): The effectiveness perceived by consumers regarding GDPR mechanisms can be correlated with their overall confidence in understanding GDPR rights (Q9) and their frequency of encountering privacy notices (Q11). This can reveal if higher awareness correlates with a perception of effectiveness in these mechanisms.
- Research Question 4 (Strategies for Personalised Marketing): Strategies that could be adopted for GDPR-compliant personalised marketing might relate to the overall

perception of GDPR's relevance (Q8) and experiences with personalised marketing (Q10). By correlating these perceptions with demographic information or levels of tech-savviness (Q5), businesses can identify targeted strategies that resonate with specific consumer segments.

Based on the options for survey questions we can categorise variables into continuous and ordinal variables. e.g data for age and confidence score could be using Pearson correlation coefficient and rest of the questions which are based on Likert scale need to be normalised to Spearman's Rank correlation coefficient (de Winter and Gosling, 2016).

- To perform this step we will import the survey data to Rapid miner
With Rapid miner we will look under the operators section to use the blending option to convert ordinal variables to numerical. This will be done in the data process phase where components can be connected with drag and drop functionality.

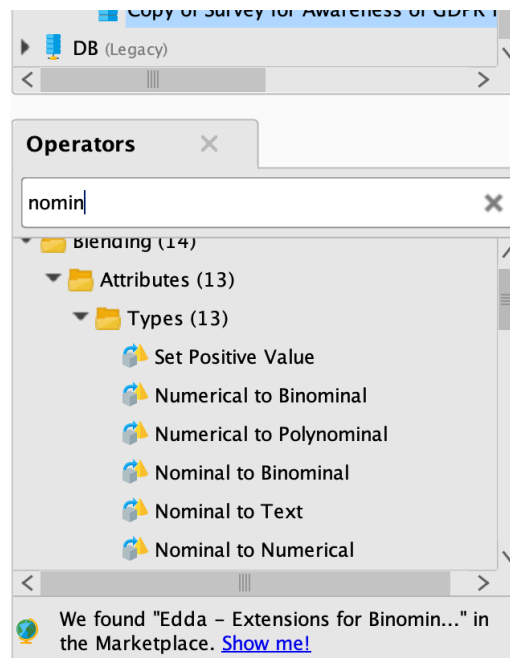


Fig 13: Converting nominal values to numerical in Rapidminer

- Once the data is ready for analysis, we select the Correlation matrix under Modeling. In addition to this we also setup auto-model to perform general regression and logistic regression to compare the results and identify optimal linkage for our research questions

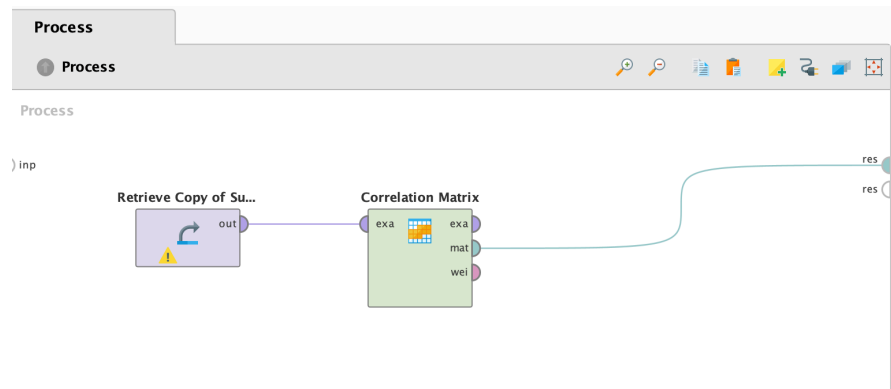


Fig 14: Setup components to run correlation matrix in Rapidminer

After successfully running the above steps we arrive at a correlation matrix which can be seen as a heatmap matrix with columns and rows as attributes. The values above the diagonal are positively correlated whereas below the diagonal are negatively correlated.

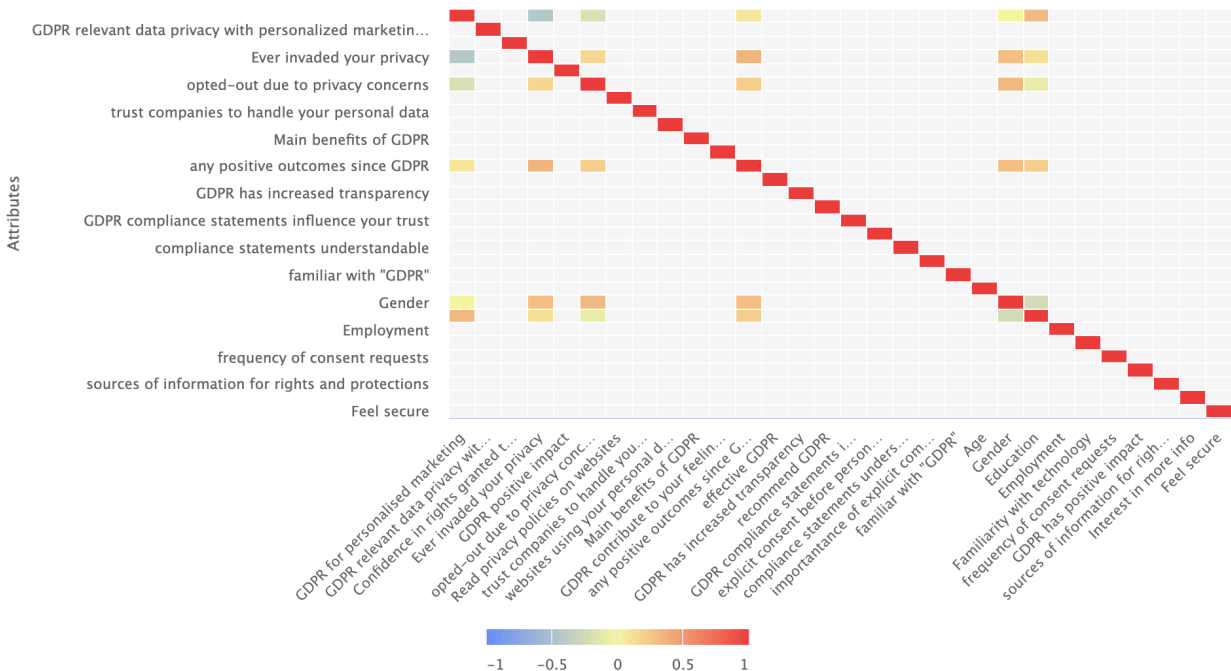


Fig 15: Correlation matrix as heatmap with columns and rows as attributes

This analysis explores consumer awareness and perceptions regarding data collection practices for personalised marketing, informed by the findings from our survey.

RQ1: Consumer Awareness of Data Collection Practices

The survey findings suggest a growing level of consumer awareness regarding data collection practices employed for personalised marketing. Notably, the strong positive correlation (0.938) between transparency of GDPR and awareness indicates that increased communication surrounding the regulation has significantly impacted consumer knowledge. Additionally, 70% of respondents reported having heard of GDPR at some point, suggesting a relatively high level of overall awareness about data collection practices associated with personalised marketing. However, it's important to acknowledge the potential for a gap between awareness and understanding. While consumers might be aware of GDPR's existence, detailed knowledge about specific rights and regulations might be limited (as potentially indicated by the lack of strong correlation between awareness and confidence in understanding GDPR rights observed in our data).

Furthermore, the survey design might have skewed the results towards a more tech-savvy population (Q5). Future research with a broader demographic sample could provide a more comprehensive picture of consumer awareness across different segments.

Attributes	Freque...	Freque...	GDPR h...	GDPR h...	GDPR has positively impacted the protection of personal informati... ↓
GDPR has positively impacted the protection of per...	0.170	0.061	-0.876	-0.178	1
Has GDPR has increased transparency in how comp...	0.174	0.066	-0.817	-0.176	0.938
GDPR relevant to your personal data privacy = Neu...	0.188	-0.012	-0.241	-0.081	0.272
Familiarity with technology = Advanced	-0.146	-0.089	-0.149	-0.138	0.230
Does websites that display GDPR compliance state...	0.058	0.048	-0.146	-0.025	0.180
Frequently of privacy notices or consent requests re...	1	-0.089	-0.234	0.165	0.170
Are the GDPR compliance statements displayed on ...	0.017	0.025	-0.025	-0.218	0.148
Education = Bachelor's degree	-0.020	-0.068	-0.087	-0.058	0.133
Comfortable with websites using your personal data...	0.150	-0.112	-0.091	-0.033	0.128
Have you opted-out due to privacy concerns relate...	-0.109	-0.040	-0.087	0.039	0.107

Table 1: Table showing correlation between increase in transparency of GDPR positively impacting perception of protecting personal data

RQ2: Trade-Offs Between Personalization and Privacy Across Demographics

The survey findings suggest that the trade-off between personalization and data privacy might not vary significantly across different consumer segments (age, gender, and technology familiarity).

Attributes	Age = ...	Age = ...	Age = ...	Gender = Female ↓
How likely are you to recommend GDPR as a model for data prote...	-0.060	-0.025	0.154	-0.069
Comfortable with websites using your personal data for personaliz...	-0.015	0.031	-0.020	-0.071
Is GDPR effective in preventing unauthorised use of your personal i...	-0.111	0.063	0.020	-0.092
how confident are you in your understanding of the specific rights ...	0.101	-0.060	-0.077	-0.095
Familiar with "GDPR" = Not Very Familiar	-0.038	0.080	-0.016	-0.097
Trust companies to handle your personal data responsibly = Yes, ...	-0.093	0.025	0.063	-0.105
Should companies obtain your explicit consent before using your p...	0.008	-0.122	0.077	-0.113
Main benefits of GDPR in protecting your personal data = Enhance...	-0.001	0.040	-0.093	-0.118
Employment = Employed	0.070	-0.115	0.110	-0.120
GDPR has positively impacted the protection of personal informati...	0.010	-0.041	0.008	-0.121

Table 2: Table showing weak correlation between positive impact of GDPR with respect to demographic

We observed weak correlations observed between these factors and privacy concerns with respect to personalization (0.01 and -0.12 respectively) that indicates a potential for a generalised concern for data privacy that transcends these demographics. This could be interpreted in a few ways:

- Privacy as a Universal Concern: Data privacy might be a growing concern for a wider population, regardless of age, gender, or tech-savviness.
- Limited Scope of the Survey: The survey questions might not have captured the nuances of user preferences regarding different types of personalization. For example, some users might be more comfortable with personalization based on browsing history but less comfortable with location-based targeting.

Further research with more specific questions about different types of personalization and their perceived privacy implications could provide a clearer picture of potential variations across consumer segments.

Attributes	Age = ...	Age = ...	Age = ...	Familiarity with technology = Adv...	Familiarity with technology = Inter...
How likely are you to recommend GDPR as a model for data prote...	-0.060	-0.025	0.154	-0.016	0.049
Comfortable with websites using your personal data for personaliz...	-0.015	0.031	-0.020	-0.117	0.049
Is GDPR effective in preventing unauthorised use of your personal i...	-0.111	0.063	0.020	-0.015	-0.049
how confident are you in your understanding of the specific rights ...	0.101	-0.060	-0.077	0.103	0.016
Familiar with "GDPR" = Not Very Familiar	-0.038	0.080	-0.016	0.047	-0.143
Trust companies to handle your personal data responsibly = Yes, ...	-0.093	0.025	0.063	-0.022	-0.017
Should companies obtain your explicit consent before using your p...	0.008	-0.122	0.077	0.231	-0.182
Main benefits of GDPR in protecting your personal data = Enhance...	-0.001	0.040	-0.093	-0.077	0.075
Employment = Employed	0.070	-0.115	0.110	0.028	-0.029
GDPR has positively impacted the protection of personal informati...	0.010	-0.041	0.008	-0.149	-0.014

Table 3: Table showing weak correlation familiarity with technology at advanced and intermediate levels don't show strong linkage with positive impact of GDPR

Similarly the correlation between familiarity with technology at advanced and intermediate levels don't show strong linkage with positive impact of GDPR

RQ3: User Perception on Opt-In/Opt-Out Mechanisms

The high opt-out rate (70.11% of respondents opting out due to privacy concerns) suggests that a significant portion of users perceive existing opt-in and opt-out mechanisms for data collection as inadequate or lacking in transparency. This highlights a need for businesses to re-evaluate their data collection practices and ensure clear communication around:

- Informing users as to what data is collected.
- How easy and user-friendly opt-out options are present on website

Statistics

< > Have you opted-out due to privacy concerns related to GDPR

Summary

Category

Missing: 0.00%

Infinite: 0.00%

ID-ness: 1.15%

Stability: 70.11%

Valid: 28.74%

Top Values



2 Distinct Values:

Value	Count	Percentage
Yes	122	70.11%
No	52	29.89%

Fig 16: Figure displaying distribution of respondents that have opted out due to privacy concerns at some stage of their online journey

The weak correlation between opt-outs and weak messaging/actions (0.19) might indicate that simply improving communication or user experience might not be the sole solution. However, the finding that over 60% of respondents want permission for marketing use of data underscores the value of clear communication and transparency in building trust.

Attributes	Age = ...	Age = ...	Age = ...	Have you opted-out due to privacy concerns related to GDPR = Yes ↓
Have you opted-out due to privacy concerns related to GDPR = Yes	-0.067	0.112	-0.120	1
Does GDPR contribute to your feeling of control over your personal...	-0.025	0.015	0.002	0.198
Should companies obtain your explicit consent before using your p...	-0.122	0.159	-0.066	0.122
Education = Master's degree	-0.095	0.068	-0.019	0.121
Age = 25-34	-0.805	1	-0.336	0.112
How likely are you to recommend GDPR as a model for data prote...	0.051	-0.066	0.014	0.112
GDPR has positively impacted the protection of personal informati...	-0.029	0.058	-0.019	0.107
Do you feel more secure engaging with websites that explicitly me...	0.075	-0.090	0.038	0.104
Comfortable with websites using your personal data for personaliz...	0.079	-0.078	0.054	0.100
Has GDPR has increased transparency in how companies handle y...	0.005	0.048	-0.063	0.100
Familiarity with technology = Advanced	0.131	-0.085	-0.057	0.099
Should companies obtain your explicit consent before using your p...	0.008	-0.122	0.077	0.098

Table 4: Table showing weak correlation between contribution of GDPR to have perception of control over personalised data and user having opted out due to privacy concerns

To promote online trust consumers want a sense of control over their personal data. This can be seen as per the small correlation between users who have opted out due to privacy concerns since they were not convinced based on their experience with certain websites due to weak messaging and actions.

RQ4: Balancing Personalization and Privacy in a GDPR-Compliant Way

We observed a moderate correlation coefficient between users trusting companies to handle personal data responsibility versus if the companies should obtain our explicit permission to use our data for marketing purposes.

Attributes	Age = ...	Age = ...	Trust companies to handle your personal data responsibly ...
Trust companies to handle your person... The column Attributes	-0.093	0.025	1
Should companies obtain your explicit c...	0.008	-0.122	0.151
Interested in receiving more information...	0.096	-0.046	0.143
Familiar with "GDPR" = Neutral	0.029	-0.134	0.138
how confident are you in your understand...	-0.070	0.023	0.137
Education = Bachelor's degree	0.142	-0.089	0.133
Comfortable with websites using your p...	-0.015	0.031	0.102
Employment = Employed	0.070	-0.115	0.100
Main benefits of GDPR in protecting you...	-0.062	-0.096	0.099
GDPR in the context of personalised ma...	-0.075	0.025	0.090
Main benefits of GDPR in protecting you...	-0.001	0.040	0.087
Is it important for you that a website ex...	0.040	-0.035	0.084

Table 5: Table showing moderate correlation between users trusting companies that seek explicitly consent for personal data

To further support this argument we have the survey result where more than 73% respondents have agreed that a company should take permission before using their personal information for any marketing purpose.

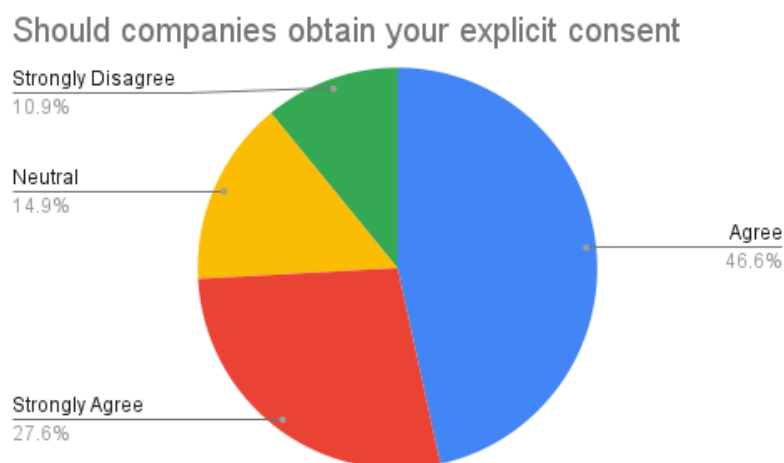


Fig 17: Distribution of respondents that demonstrate almost 73% folks would expect companies to obtain explicit consent for personal data

Chapter 5: Discussion

In this comprehensive exploration of the impact of personalised marketing and the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) on modern commerce, several key insights have emerged. The dynamic landscape of commerce has been significantly influenced by the convergence of digital technology, data analytics, and consumer connectivity (Quach et al., 2022). Businesses have shifted from traditional one-size-fits-all marketing approaches to personalised marketing strategies, leveraging consumer data to tailor experiences and drive engagement. The promise of personalised marketing lies in its ability to enhance customer engagement, drive conversions, and foster long-term loyalty through relevant and personalised content.

However, alongside the rise of personalised marketing, there has been a growing demand for data privacy among consumers (Acquisti, Taylor and Wagman, 2016). The GDPR, a landmark initiative introduced by the European Union in 2018, has played a pivotal role in reshaping data collection and usage practices. By emphasising transparency, consent, and control over personal data, the GDPR aims to restore consumer trust and confidence in the digital ecosystem (van Ooijen and Vrabec, 2018). Businesses are now required to provide clear information about data practices, obtain explicit consent for data processing, and grant individuals control over their data.

5.1 Key findings and contributions

The study offers valuable insights into the evolving landscape of consumer privacy concerns and personalised marketing strategies:

- **Growing Awareness of Data Collection Practices:** The strong correlation between GDPR transparency and awareness suggests that increased communication surrounding the regulation has significantly impacted consumer knowledge about data collection practices used for personalised marketing (Hemker, Herrando and Constantinides, 2021). This

highlights the effectiveness of public awareness campaigns and educational efforts in promoting data privacy literacy.

- **Privacy Concerns Transcend Demographics:** The weak correlations between age, gender, and technology familiarity with privacy concerns during personalization suggest a potential for a more generalised concern for data privacy that transcends these demographics. This finding emphasises the importance of data privacy as a growing consumer priority across various segments.
- **High Opt-Out Rates and Need for Improved Opt-In/Opt-Out Mechanisms:** The significant number of respondents who have opted out due to privacy concerns highlights a need for businesses to re-evaluate their data collection practices and ensure clear communication around data usage and user control mechanisms (Rosário and Dias, 2023). Existing opt-in/opt-out systems might be perceived as inadequate or lacking transparency, prompting users to opt-out entirely.
- **Balancing Personalization and Privacy:** The findings highlight the need for businesses to navigate the balance between personalization and privacy in a GDPR-compliant manner (Grace Fox and Lynn, 2019). Implementing strategies like transparency, consent-based personalization, data minimization, and robust security measures can foster trust with consumers while still offering relevant and personalised marketing experiences.

The study contributes to the ongoing conversation about data privacy and personalised marketing by providing empirical evidence on consumer awareness, perceptions, and opt-out behaviours. It highlights the importance of building trust with users through transparency, user control, and clear communication practices.

5.2 Comparing with existing findings

To set a benchmark for the survey and study that we conducted a standard way is to compare it with recent studies and look for improvements or gaps. Below are some recent surveys conducted on similar topics.

General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) awareness for users in selected European countries in 2018 and 2022



Fig 18: Study indicating growth in awareness of GDPR among European countries (statista, 2022)

This study conducted across European countries between 2018 and 2022 demonstrates a substantial increase in awareness of GDPR regulations. This upward trend in GDPR awareness signifies a positive shift towards better understanding and compliance with data protection laws. The survey results, reflecting users' familiarity with GDPR and its impact on personal data privacy, align with the broader trend of heightened awareness and consciousness regarding data protection rights.

Main motivation of becoming more privacy conscious in the United Kingdom (UK) as of February 2023

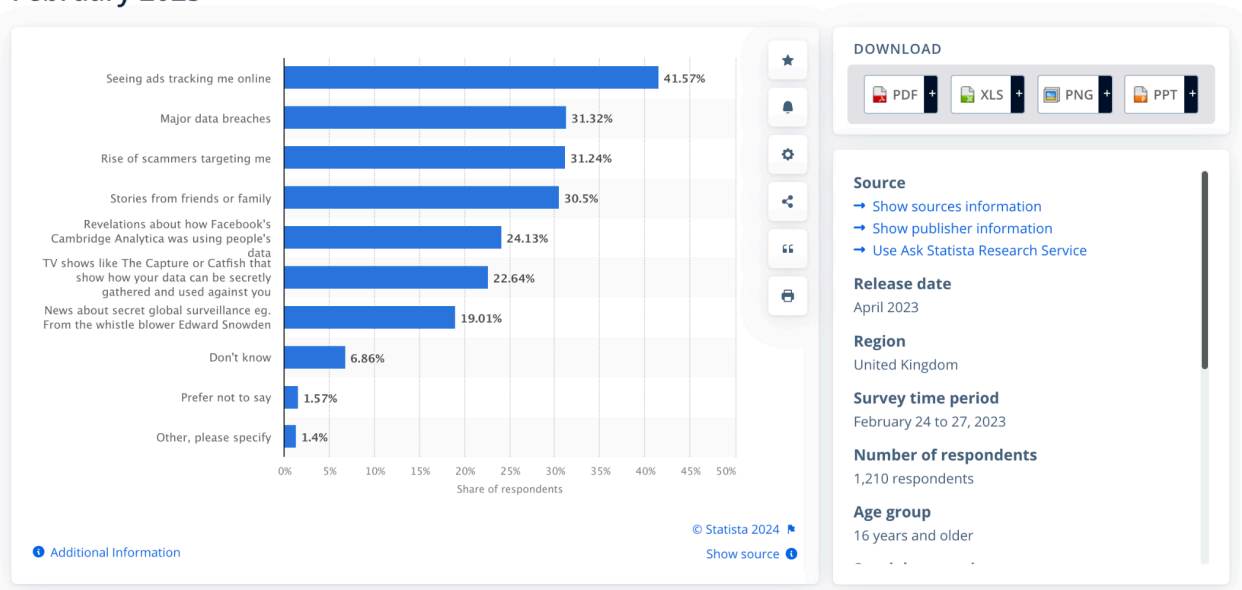


Fig 19: Study discussing primary motivation behind UK becoming more privacy conscious (statista, 2023)

Earlier studies have indicated that a primary motivation for individuals to become more privacy-conscious in the UK is the tracking of online ads. This aligns with the survey results, highlighting a persistent lack of trust in companies, even with the implementation of GDPR. Users' concerns about online tracking and personalised marketing reflect a broader trend of scepticism towards data handling practices.

User attitudes toward personal information tracking in the United Kingdom (UK) as of February 2023

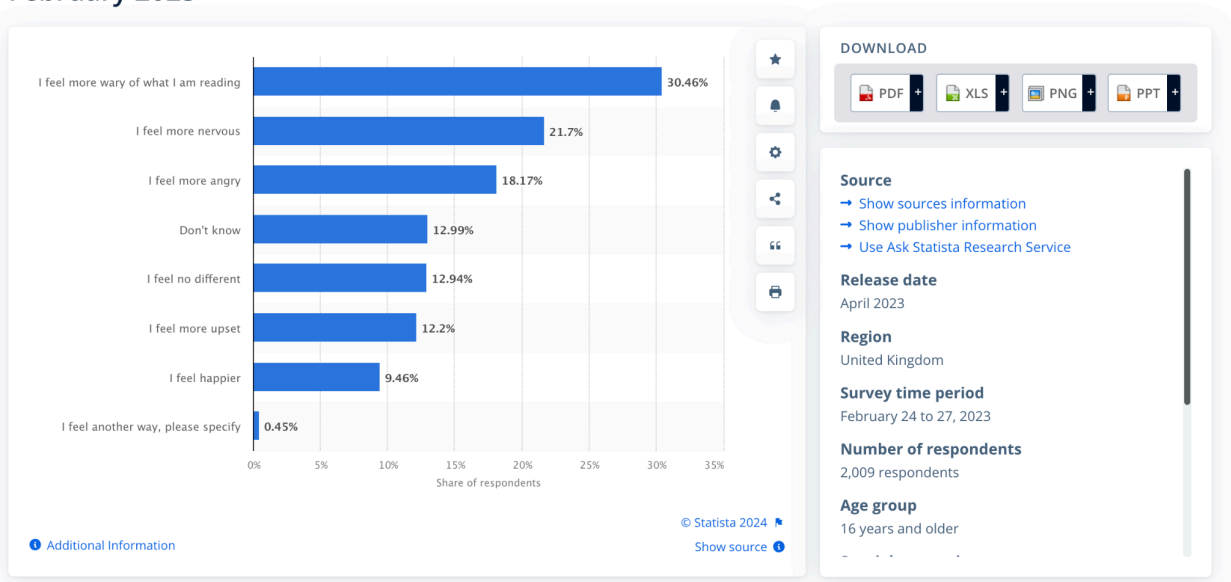


Fig 20: Study indicating individuals are becoming increasingly cautious about the content they explore online (statista, 2023)

Recent research on user attitudes towards personal information tracking in the UK reveals that individuals are increasingly cautious about the content they encounter online. The survey findings corroborate this sentiment, with users expressing wariness when exploring new websites. This heightened sense of vigilance underscores the growing importance of transparency and data protection measures in online interactions.

Comparing these findings with earlier studies sheds light on the evolving landscape of data protection and user attitudes towards privacy

5.3 Limitations and future research directions

While the study offers valuable insights, it acknowledges some limitations:

- **Sample Demographics:** The potentially tech-savvy sample demographic (Q3, Q5) might limit the generalizability of findings to the broader population. Future research with more diverse samples could provide a more comprehensive picture of consumer awareness and privacy concerns across different segments.

- **Survey Design:** The survey questions might not have captured the nuances of user preferences regarding different types of personalization (e.g., browsing history vs. location-based targeting). Further research with more specific questions about personalization methods and their perceived privacy implications could offer a more detailed understanding of user preferences.
- **Qualitative Research Opportunities:** The study primarily relies on quantitative data. Incorporating qualitative research methods like focus groups or in-depth interviews could provide a deeper understanding of the reasons behind user opt-outs and their expectations regarding data collection and personalization practices.
- **Correlation does not imply causation:** It's crucial to remember that correlation does not imply causation. Just because two variables are correlated doesn't necessarily mean one causes the other. Further investigation might be needed to explore the underlying reasons behind the observed correlations.

Future research could explore:

- The effectiveness of specific transparency and control mechanisms in promoting user trust and reducing opt-out rates.
- The impact of different types of personalization methods on user privacy concerns and perceived value.
- The evolving consumer landscape as data privacy regulations, technology, and consumer expectations continue to change.

5.4 Practical and research implications

The survey responses on awareness of GDPR regulations provide valuable insights for both practical applications and further research. Businesses that want to build trust with consumers in the era of GDPR and personalised marketing require a fork approach (Chiantera, 2018):

- **Transparency and User Control:** Businesses should be transparent about their data collection practices and provide users with clear control over how their data is used. This includes easily accessible opt-out options and the ability to manage user profiles and data preferences.

- **Consent-Based Personalization:** Obtaining explicit consent for using personal data for marketing purposes is crucial. Pre-checked boxes or unclear language around data usage should be avoided.
- **Data Minimization:** Businesses should collect only the data necessary for legitimate business purposes and avoid collecting excessive or irrelevant data.
- **Data Security Measures:** Implementing robust data security measures to protect user information from unauthorised access or misuse is essential for building trust (Fox, Lynn and Rosati, 2022).
- **Contextual Personalization:** Techniques like contextual personalization, which rely on analysing user behaviour within a specific session or platform, can offer a level of personalization without requiring extensive user data collection.

On the research front, the survey responses offer a rich dataset for analysing the impact of GDPR on user perceptions and behaviours. Researchers can dive deeper into specific factors influencing individuals' attitudes towards data privacy, such as the frequency of consent requests, sources of information on rights and protections, and the perceived benefits of GDPR (Clarke et al., 2019). Additionally, comparing responses across age groups, genders, education levels, and familiarity with technology can provide valuable insights into how different segments of the population interact with and perceive GDPR regulations. This data can fuel further academic investigations into the effectiveness of GDPR in enhancing user privacy and trust in online platforms.

5.5 Conclusion

In the era of GDPR and heightened consumer awareness, navigating the balance between personalization and privacy remains a key challenge for businesses. This research highlights the growing public understanding of data collection practices and the importance of data privacy as a consumer concern. Businesses that prioritise transparency, user control, and responsible data collection practices can win consumer trust and continue to develop effective personalised marketing strategies within the evolving regulatory framework. By continuously adapting to changing regulations and user expectations, businesses can ensure they are offering consumers a valuable and privacy-conscious personalised marketing experience (Anant et al., 2020).

In conclusion, our study offers valuable insights into consumer perceptions and preferences for personalised marketing in the era of GDPR. Through a rigorous research methodology encompassing survey sampling, questionnaire design, quantitative analysis, and interpretation of findings, we have identified key factors influencing consumer attitudes and behaviours. Our findings underscore the importance of transparency, user control, and trustworthiness in shaping consumer perceptions of personalised marketing and data privacy.

Despite its limitations, including a small sample size and potential biases in survey design and respondent behaviour, our study contributes to the existing body of knowledge in several ways. By highlighting the complex interplay between customization and data privacy, we provide actionable insights for businesses and policymakers seeking to navigate the challenges of personalised marketing in the GDPR era. Our study sets the stage for future research in this area, suggesting avenues for further exploration, such as cultural differences, trust in technology, and perceptions of data security.

Moving forward, businesses can leverage our findings to develop strategies that prioritise transparency, respect consumer privacy preferences, and build trust through clear communication and actions. By aligning marketing practices with consumer expectations and regulatory requirements, organisations can enhance consumer trust and satisfaction in the digital marketplace. Moreover, policymakers can use our insights to inform regulations and policies that promote consumer privacy and data protection in the age of personalised marketing (Aridor, Che and Salz, 2020)(brown, 2023).

In summary, our study provides a foundation for further research and practical applications in the field of personalised marketing and data privacy. By addressing the complexities and challenges of this evolving landscape, we contribute to a more informed and responsible approach to consumer engagement in the digital age.

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Appendices

Appendix 1: Ethical approval letter



College of Business, Arts and Social Sciences Research Ethics Committee
Brunel University London
Kingston Lane
Uxbridge UB8 3PH
United Kingdom www.brunel.ac.uk

26 September 2023

LETTER OF APPROVAL

APPROVAL HAS BEEN GRANTED FOR THIS STUDY TO BE CARRIED OUT BETWEEN 26/09/2023 AND 15/03/2024

Applicant (s): Miss Riya Singh

Project Title: Consumer Perceptions and Preferences for Personalised Marketing in the Era of GDPR: Balancing Customisation and Data Privacy

Reference: 44805-LR-Sep/2023- 47271-2

Dear Miss Riya Singh

The Research Ethics Committee has considered the above application recently submitted by you.

The Chair, acting under delegated authority has agreed that there is no objection on ethical grounds to the proposed study. Approval is given on the understanding that the conditions of approval set out below are followed:

- **The agreed protocol must be followed. Any changes to the protocol will require prior approval from the Committee by way of an application for an amendment.**
- **Please ensure that you monitor and adhere to all up-to-date local and national Government health advice for the duration of your project.**

Please note that:

Research Participant Information Sheets and (where relevant) flyers, posters, and consent forms should include a clear statement that research ethics approval has been obtained from the relevant Research Ethics Committee.

The Research Participant Information Sheets should include a clear statement that queries should be directed, in the first instance, to the Supervisor (where relevant), or the researcher. Complaints, on the other hand, should be directed, in the first instance, to the Chair of the relevant Research Ethics Committee.

Approval to proceed with the study is granted subject to any conditions that may appear above.

The Research Ethics Committee reserves the right to sample and review documentation, including raw data, relevant to the study.

If your project has been approved to run for a duration longer than 12 months, you will be required to submit an annual progress report to the Research Ethics Committee. You will be contacted about submission of this report before it becomes due.

You may not undertake any research activity if you are not a registered student of Brunel University or if you cease to become registered, including abeyance or temporary withdrawal. As a deregistered student you would not be insured to undertake research activity. Research activity includes the recruitment of participants, undertaking consent procedures and collection of data. Breach of this requirement constitutes research misconduct and is a disciplinary offence.

Dr Katja Sarmiento-Mirwaldt
Chair of the College of Business, Arts and Social Sciences Research Ethics Committee Brunel University London

Appendix 2: Participant information sheet



PARTICIPANT INFORMATION SHEET

Study title:

Consumer Perceptions and Preferences for Personalized Marketing in the Era of GDPR:
Balancing Customization and Data Privacy

Invitation Paragraph:

You are being asked to take part in a research study. Before you decide, it is important for you to understand why the research is being done and what it will involve. Please take time to read the following information carefully and discuss it with others if you wish. Ask me/us if there is anything that is not clear or if you would like more information. Take time to decide whether or not you wish to take part. Thank you for reading this.

What is the purpose of the study?

This study is part of coursework for M.Sc. Business intelligence and digital marketing. The study aims to address a significant gap in knowledge by investigating how consumers perceive personalised marketing efforts, the extent of their awareness regarding data collection and usage for personalisation, and the factors influencing their preferences.

Why have I been invited to participate?

People who are above the age of 18+ are eligible to take part in this survey. To make the survey more inclusive, we have invited people from diverse backgrounds and age groups.

Do I have to take part?

As participation is entirely voluntary, it is up to you to decide whether or not to take part. If you do decide to take part you will be given this information sheet to keep and you may be asked to sign a consent form. If you decide not to take part then you are allowed to withdraw at any time up until 01-03-2024 after which your details will be anonymised and you would be unable to withdraw.

Withdrawal from the study will in no way adversely affect the participant

What will happen to me if I take part?

This study is based on an anonymised survey so the participants can't be identified. The duration of the survey questionnaire should take less than 5 mins

Are there any lifestyle restrictions?

No

What are the possible disadvantages and risks of taking part?

There are no anticipated disadvantages or risks associated with taking part in this study.

What are the possible benefits of taking part?

There is no intended benefit to the person from taking part in the study

What if something goes wrong?

In case something goes wrong, the queries should be directed to the researcher and supervisor. Complaints should be directed to the College of Business, Arts and Social Sciences Research Ethics Committee: cbass-ethics@brunel.ac.uk

Will my taking part in this study be kept confidential?

All information which is collected about you during the course of the research will be kept strictly confidential till the submission of this study after which it will be deleted. Any information about you which leaves the University will have all your identifying information removed. With your permission, anonymised data will be stored and may be used in future research – you can indicate whether or not you give permission for this by way of the Consent Form.

Will I be recorded, and how will the recording be used?

Your survey answers will be recorded and anonymised. No audio or video recording is required.

What will happen to the results of the research study?

The results will be analysed and used for Master's dissertation and participants may request the researcher to receive a copy of the results. The participant will not be identified in any report or publication unless specifically requested by them.

Who is organising and funding the research?

The research is being organised by Riya Singh in conjunction with Brunel University London.

What are the indemnity arrangements?

Brunel University London provides appropriate insurance cover for research which has received ethical approval

Who has reviewed the study?

The study has been reviewed by Mrs. Kinana Jammoul and the College of Business, Arts and Social Sciences Research Ethics Committee Dr Katja Sarmiento-Mirwaldt, cbass-ethics@brunel.ac.uk

Thank you for taking time to read through the PIS form.

Research Integrity

Brunel University London is committed to compliance with the Universities UK [Research Integrity Concordat](#). You are entitled to expect the highest level of integrity from the researchers during the course of this research

Contact for further information and complaints

For complaints, Chair of the Research Ethics Committee:

College of Business Arts and Social Sciences Research Ethics Committee:
Dr Katja Sarmiento-Mirwaldt, cbass-ethics@brunel.ac.uk

Researcher name and

details: Name: Riya Singh

Email: @brunel.ac.uk

Supervisor name and details:

Name: Mrs. Kinana Jammoul

Email: kinana.jammoul2@brunel.ac.uk

Appendix 3: Survey cover letter

Invitation to Participate in Research Survey

Dear Participant,

We invite you to take part in our research study on consumer perceptions and preferences for personalized marketing in the era of GDPR. If you are 18 and above, you're eligible to take part in this survey. Your insights are invaluable in helping us understand how individuals like you view personalized marketing practices.

Participation entails completing a brief survey, which should take approximately 5 minutes of your time. Your responses will remain anonymous.

Your input contributes to enhancing consumer experiences and guiding businesses in aligning their practices with data protection regulations.

Your involvement is entirely voluntary, and you can withdraw at any time without penalty.

Rest assured that all responses are confidential and securely stored.

To begin, please click on the following link to access the survey: [Survey Link]

Thank you for considering participation. Your contribution is greatly appreciated and will contribute to valuable insights in the field of personalized marketing and data privacy.

Thank you,

Riya Singh

[@brunel.ac.uk](mailto:riya.singh@brunel.ac.uk)

Appendix 4: Survey questionnaire

Q1: What is your age range?

- a. 18-24
- b. 25-34
- c. 35-44
- d. 45+

Q2: What is your Gender?

- a. Male
- b. Female
- c. Non-binary
- d. Prefer not to say

Q3: What is your highest level of education??

- a. High school or equivalent
- b. Some college or vocational training
- c. Bachelor's degree
- d. Master's degree
- e. Other

Q4: What is your employment status?

- a. Employed
- b. Unemployed
- c. Student
- d. Retired
- e. Other

Q5: How would you describe your level of familiarity with technology?

- a. Novice
- b. Intermediate

c. Advanced

Q6: How familiar are you with the term "GDPR" (General Data Protection Regulation) ?

- a. Very Familiar
- b. Somewhat Familiar
- c. Neutral
- d. Not Very Familiar
- e. Not Familiar at All

Q7: Have you ever encountered or read about GDPR in the context of personalised marketing?

- a. Yes
- b. No

Q8: Do you think GDPR is relevant to your personal data privacy when engaging with digital marketing ?

- a. Highly Relevant
- b. Somewhat Relevant
- c. Neutral
- d. Not Very Relevant
- e. Not Relevant at All

response summary:

Q9: On a scale of 1 to 10, how confident are you in your understanding of the specific rights granted to you by GDPR ?

- a. 1-3 (Low Confidence)
- b. 4-6 (Moderate Confidence)
- c. 7-8 (High Confidence)
- d. 9-10 (Very High Confidence)

Q10: Have you ever encountered a personalised marketing message that made you feel uncomfortable or invaded your privacy?

- a. Yes
- b. No

Q11: How frequently do you come across privacy notices or consent requests related to GDPR when using online services ?

- a. Very Frequently
- b. Frequently
- c. Occasionally
- d. Rarely
- e. Never

Q12: Do you believe that GDPR has positively impacted the protection of your personal information online?

- a. Strongly Agree
- b. Agree
- c. Neutral
- d. Disagree
- e. Strongly Disagree

Q13: What sources do you rely on to stay informed about your rights and protections under GDPR?

- a. News Articles
- b. Social Media
- c. Online Forums
- d. Other

Q14: Would you be interested in receiving more information about GDPR and how it affects your online privacy?

- a. Very Interested
- b. Interested

- c. Neutral
- d. Not Very Interested
- e. Not Interested at All

Q15: Do you feel more secure engaging with websites that explicitly mention GDPR compliance

- a. Strongly Agree
- b. Agree
- c. Neutral
- d. Disagree
- e. Strongly Disagree

Q16: Do you believe that GDPR has had a positive impact on protecting consumer privacy in the era of personalised marketing?

- a. Very High Impact
- b. Moderate Impact
- c. Low Impact
- d. No Impact
- e. Don't Know

Q17: Have you ever opted-out or refrained from participating in online activities due to privacy concerns related to GDPR?

- a. Yes
- b. No

Q18: How likely are you to read privacy policies on websites, considering your awareness of GDPR?

- a. Very Likely

- b. Likely
- c. Neutral
- d. Unlikely
- e. Very Unlikely

Q19: How much do you trust companies to handle your personal data responsibly and protect your privacy?

- a. Yes, significantly
- b. Yes, to some extent
- c. No, not really
- d. No, not at all

Q20: How comfortable are you with the idea of websites using your personal data for personalised marketing, considering GDPR?

- a. Very Comfortable
- b. Comfortable
- c. Neutral
- d. Uncomfortable
- e. Very Uncomfortable